

THE BUILD PLAYBOOK

How we actually build one of these, start to finish, in the right order.

This is the process, not the copy. It documents the correct sequence for building a \$9/mo Skool community + info product from zero – written from building THE SCENE AI, reusable for the next one. We did these 15 phases out of order the first time (brand voice got decided mid-way, ads got written before the funnel was even live). Here is the order that wastes the least time.

Rule of the whole playbook: each phase locks before the next one starts. Skipping ahead is how you end up rewriting a \$97 tier's module numbers after the PDFs are already rendered – which is exactly what happened here, and this doc exists so it doesn't happen twice.

PHASE 0 • PICK THE NICHE + STUDY ONE PROVEN COMPETITOR (1-2 hrs)

Don't invent a category. Find a Skool community already winning in a neighboring space and reverse-engineer it before writing anything.

- [] Find the competitor's public Meta Ads Library (facebook.com/ads/library, search their page name). Pull 15-25 active ads.
- [] Screenshot their About page, join questions, price, trial-vs-guarantee setting.
- [] Screenshot their classroom: section names, lesson names, what's locked vs open, whether gamification/levels exist and what they pay.
- [] Note their pricing meta: is it flat, tiered, or threshold-based? Does the founding-price story hold up (do they actually raise it)?
- [] Write down: what do they NOT do that you could own? (For SCENE AI: nobody in the niche showed a persistent character moving through a world – everyone sold the skill, nobody showed the result.)

Output: one page of notes. Do not skip this even if you think you know the niche – the ad library alone saves weeks of copywriting guesswork, because it shows you what's already been tested at scale.

PHASE 1 • LOCK THE BUSINESS MODEL (30-60 min)

Decide these six things before anything else gets built. Every one of them changes downstream work if it flips later, so lock them now:

- [] Price and structure. Flat forever, or a real threshold? (We chose flat \$9 until 50k – simpler to build, no screenshot risk.)
- [] Trial vs guarantee. A 7-day money-back guarantee beats a free trial for pixel/ad reasons (real purchase event, no rip-and-run) – check what the Phase 0 competitor runs and match it.
- [] The funding rule. Decide, in writing, what personal money is and is not allowed to touch. (Ours: never past the \$9/mo platform bill – no rent, no credit, no savings. Every upgrade is bought by the

business's own revenue.)

- [] The tier split. What's in the low-price shelf vs the paid unlock? Draw this as two lists before naming a single module - renumbering after content exists is the single most expensive mistake in this whole process.
- [] The DFY/services ladder, if any. Prices, and whether it's sold by checkout link or by invoice/DM-qualify (DM qualify is safer for a young account - no chargeback surface, no scope creep from a self-serve buyer).
- [] The unlock mechanism for the paid tier - in-app one-time purchase (frictionless, small platform fee) vs external checkout (more control, more friction).

Output: a single paragraph you could recite. This is the spine everything else hangs off.

PHASE 2 • BUILD THE BRAND IDENTITY (1-2 hrs) BEFORE ANY CONTENT

This is the phase we did last, out of order, and had to retrofit into finished PDFs. Do it second. Everything downstream reads faster and needs less revision once this exists.

- [] Name + one-liner + tagline. One sentence a stranger could repeat back.
- [] The world/metaphor the brand lives in. (Ours: it's a real production - members are directors, not students; content is "produced" and "released," not "made" and "posted.") Pick one metaphor and commit completely - half a metaphor reads as confused, not clever.
- [] The two voices. Funnel voice (outside, sells hard) vs inside voice (members already paid, selling language only survives on closed doors). Write one paragraph of each.
- [] The language table. A literal "never say / always say" list. This is the single highest-leverage artifact in the whole build - every future copy pass just checks against this table instead of re-deciding word choice every time.
- [] Visual identity. Palette (hex codes, not "kind of purple"), fonts, logo lockup, one-sentence art direction for any AI-generated imagery, cover rules for what survives a mobile thumbnail.
- [] Copy rules. Punctuation (we ban em dashes), emoji kit (which ones are brand, which are banned), reading-level target, and any compliance lines (no income claims, no fake scarcity).
- [] Write it all into one BRAND BIBLE document and treat it as done - don't let it keep drifting as content gets written. Update it deliberately, not by accident.

Output: **BRAND-BIBLE.md** - the file every future copy decision gets checked against.

PHASE 3 • ARCHITECT THE PRODUCT (1-2 hrs)

With the tier split from Phase 1 and the brand from Phase 2, lay out the full content map before writing a single lesson.

- [] List every module/lesson in build order, tier by tier. Number them once, correctly, from the start - free tier gets its own number block, paid tier continues the sequence, nothing repeats across tiers. (Renumbering later means touching every cross-reference, every filename, every classroom

attachment – budget a full session for it if you get this wrong, we did.)

- [] Draw the map/roadmap graphic's content now, in outline form: what are the zones/phases/stages the whole system moves through, and what locks at each checkpoint. This becomes the flagship "start here" asset.
- [] Decide the bonus/vault content (hooks, captions, prompts) and where each one sits in the tier split.
- [] Decide the monthly-content mechanic if there is one (our "drops") – what ships every month and in what quantity.

Output: a single outline doc – every module name, its number, its tier, one line of what it teaches. This is the skeleton the render pipeline and the classroom copy both hang off.

PHASE 4 • BUILD (OR REUSE) THE CONTENT PRODUCTION PIPELINE (2-4 hrs, one-time)

If this is the first build: build a system that turns structured content into branded output, don't hand-format every asset.

- [] One structured source file (we use a JSON array of pages/elements) as the single source of truth for all module content.
- [] One render script that turns that source into branded PDFs – covers, headers, tables, prompt/code panels, flow diagrams, the roadmap graphic – using the Phase 2 visual identity as constants (hex codes, fonts) referenced once, not repeated per-file.
- [] Build custom components for anything that repeats: a "next step" banner, a worksheet card, a step-flow diagram, a system-map flowable. Building these as reusable classes once is what makes "redesign the whole roadmap" a 20-minute job instead of a re-typeset of 19 files.
- [] A file-naming convention that derives automatically from the content (doc order + title -> filename) so renumbering module order doesn't require manually renaming files.

Output: a render pipeline. On every future project this phase is "reuse and reskin," not "rebuild" – the biggest efficiency gain in this whole playbook.

PHASE 5 • WRITE THE CONTENT, MODULE BY MODULE (ONGOING – THE LONG PHASE)

Now write the actual lessons, into the Phase 4 source file, following the Phase 3 outline and the Phase 2 language table.

- [] Go in build order, one module at a time. Don't write all 19 in a rush pass – each one needs to speak to exactly where the member is standing when they open it, and that's easiest to get right one at a time with fresh attention.
- [] For each module: does the teaching text follow the language table? Do prompt/code blocks stay completely untouched (members paste those into AI tools – a "simplify this prompt" pass is the one pass that must NEVER touch prompt text)?

- [] Re-render after each module and spot check visually (render to image, actually look at it) - don't assume the structured data is right just because the script ran without errors.

Output: the finished **content_final.json** (or equivalent) and all rendered PDFs.

PHASE 6 • BUILD THE PLATFORM SHELL (30-60 min)

This can happen in parallel with Phase 5 once Phase 1-3 are locked - the group doesn't need finished content to exist.

- [] Create the group/platform. Name, URL (accept the placeholder URL if the clean one costs money you haven't earned yet - see the funding rule).
- [] Plan tier, price, trial setting, privacy, discovery - all per the Phase 1 decisions.
- [] About page: short description + full description, using Phase 2 voice and Phase 5 module list. Respect the character limit - write it AS a constrained edit, don't write long and cut later.
- [] Media gallery order, join questions (2-3 max, one of them should surface your highest-value lead type).
- [] Feed categories.

Output: a live but empty shell, ready for classroom content.

PHASE 7 • BUILD THE CLASSROOM STRUCTURE (30-45 min)

- [] Create every section from the Phase 3 outline, in order.
- [] Write a 15-20 word tile description per section - this is what members see before they click in, it's doing sales work even on "free" sections.
- [] Set access/unlock rules per section (which tier, which purchase mechanism, from Phase 1).
- [] Covers for every section and every gamification tile - generate in batches using the Phase 2 one-sentence art direction so they read as one system, not 20 separate images.

PHASE 8 • WRITE THE CLASSROOM COPY (1-2 hrs)

One lesson-by-lesson paste document - name, attached file(s), and the exact copy - built directly from Phase 5's finished modules.

- [] Every lesson needs: the file to attach (using student-facing names, not internal build filenames), and a short paste-ready description in Voice 2 (see Phase 2).
- [] Every lesson closes with the same completion line format - this feeds progress bars, which feed retention, so make it consistent enough to be a system, not a one-off nicety.
- [] Build the file manifest last: a table mapping every build output file to its student-facing name to its destination lesson. This is the checklist you actually upload from.

Output: one classroom-copy document, one file-manifest table.

PHASE 9 • BUILD THE GAMIFICATION LAYER (30-45 min)

- [] Decide the rank ladder (we used a film-crew career: Extra through Studio Head).
- [] Decide what points measure (likes-received rewards good content over spam – copy this if it fits).
- [] For each rank: a 15-word tile description + the full unlock copy + what's actually inside (a real small prize for low ranks, a real big prize for the top 2-3 – most members never reach the top ones, which is exactly why the big prizes are affordable).
- [] Set each tile's access to its matching level in platform settings.

PHASE 10 • QA PASS BEFORE ANYTHING GOES LIVE (30–60 min)

Do this before Phase 11, not after – it's cheaper to fix copy once than to fix it once live and again after a member screenshots it.

- [] Reading-level check on every customer-facing copy block. Don't eyeball it – script a Flesch-Kincaid pass over every lesson/tile/ad block and read the actual score. Fix anything over your target, in order of severity.
- [] Language-table sweep: grep the whole copy set for every "never say" word from the Phase 2 table.
- [] Duplicate-content check: does the paid tier repeat anything the free tier already sold? (Cross-check module numbers, not just titles – a rename can hide a duplicate.)
- [] Link check: every banner, every product, every doc points to the current platform URL – not a retired one.
- [] Voice check: does anything inside the paid door still use funnel words ("free," "get," "offer")?

PHASE 11 • SEED CONTENT + GO LIVE (30–60 min)

An empty platform kills signups – never launch without this phase done first.

- [] One pinned founder's-cohort post with a real, time-limited perk.
- [] Post your own best example content as member #1 – be the proof.
- [] Announce the flagship content drop/asset in the main feed.
- [] Comp 3-5 real people in free, ask each for an honest week-one review post.
- [] Run one full join end-to-end from a second account before telling anyone it's live – questions, approval, welcome, the whole path.
- [] Flip bio links, pinned posts, and any autoresponder to the real URL.

PHASE 12 • TURN ON THE ORGANIC FUNNEL (ongoing)

This runs before, during, and after ads – it never turns off.

- [] One clear call-to-action keyword, one autoresponder that sends straight to the paid door – no free lead magnet siphoning off the thing that's supposed to make people pay. (We retired ours: a free taste of the same aha the \$9 tier sells undercuts the \$9 tier.)

- [] A standing weekly content rhythm: proof posts, build-in-public posts, every post ending in the same keyword CTA.
- [] This weekly rhythm functions as the ad budget before ads exist - organic reach at zero cost is real reach, log it as such when deciding if the money rule's gate is met.

PHASE 13 • ADS ONLY AFTER THE MONEY RULE'S GATE IS MET

Don't write ads before Phase 0-12 are live - an ad with nowhere good to land is wasted spend, and you already spent Phase 0 studying a competitor's library, so most of the writing work is already done.

- [] Re-check the Phase 1 funding gate: is it revenue-funded, or does a genuinely spare war chest exist? Confirm before spending a dollar.
- [] Write one ad per proven angle from the Phase 0 competitor study (we used 5: cost-truth, craft, social-proof, no-camera, beginner- safety) - same skeleton every time: bold claim, plain mechanism, checklist of what's inside, price-minimized, risk reversal, one link.
- [] Hold any social-proof/member-count ad until the real number is worth bragging about.
- [] Deploy as a runway (small daily spend over many weeks), not a bang. Kill underperformers by CPA threshold, duplicate winners instead of rewriting them.
- [] Compliance pass: no income claims, no number that isn't true yet, guarantee language matches what Skool/the platform actually has configured.

PHASE 14 • CONSOLIDATE INTO REFERENCE DOCUMENTS (1 hr)

Do this once the system is live and stable, and again after any major redesign.

- [] One MASTER BUILD document: every setting, every lesson, every piece of copy, the file manifest, the funnel, the ads - the entire operable business in build order, so anyone (including future you) can stand up the whole thing from one file.
- [] Confirm the BRAND BIBLE from Phase 2 still matches reality - update it if voice/visual decisions shifted during the build (they will).
- [] Retire or clearly mark any older docs these two supersede, so there's exactly one source of truth per topic.

PHASE 15 • THE STANDING LOOP (forever, after launch)

- [] Monthly content drop, on schedule, every month.
- [] Weekly organic content rhythm continues.
- [] Watch the funding gate - the moment revenue clears it, execute the next unlock (platform upgrade, ad spend) same-day, don't let cash sit idle past its own rule.
- [] Any copy change gets checked against the Brand Bible and re-tested for reading level before it ships - QA is not a one-time phase, it's a standing gate on every future edit.

THE FIVE MISTAKES THIS PLAYBOOK EXISTS TO PREVENT

1. Writing content before locking module numbers. Renumbering after the fact touches every filename, every cross-reference, every classroom attachment. Lock the outline in Phase 3, before Phase 5.
2. Deciding brand voice after content already exists. Retrofitting language rules into finished copy is a full re-edit. Brand Bible is Phase 2, before any lesson gets written.
3. Writing ads before the platform they land on is actually finished and tested. Phase 13 is deliberately near the end.
4. Skipping the reading-level/language QA pass and finding the issues only when a member points them out. Phase 10 is a checklist, not a vibe check.
5. Letting a free lead magnet undercut the paid tier's core hook. Decide the funnel's shape (Phase 1) before building any lead magnet at all - retrofitting this after launch means retiring something members already associate with the brand.

TIME BUDGET (if run in this order, back to back)

Research + model + brand + architecture (Phases 0-3): half a day. Pipeline build, one-time (Phase 4): half a day. Content writing (Phase 5): the long pole - budget one focused session per module. Platform + classroom + gamification (Phases 6-9): half a day. QA + seed + launch (Phases 10-11): half a day. Funnel + ads (Phases 12-13): ongoing, ads only after the gate. Consolidation (Phase 14): one hour, do it twice - once at launch, once after any big redesign.

Doing Phases 0-4 in order before Phase 5 starts is the single biggest efficiency gain available - it's the difference between writing each module once versus writing it, renaming it, and re-voicing it later.